FORGE

PHASE 2 — DEVELOPMENT

Week 18 of 36

Simulation Training Block 1b

Sessions 52–54

Week 18: Simulation Training Block 1b

Facilitator Notes for Week 18

Week 18 finishes Simulation Block 1 with three dorm scenarios that call for more judgment than the first two. In Session 52, men with seniority are pushing a new arrival off his bunk, a FORGE participant is standing with them, and the new man says he doesn't want help. In Session 53, a man who owes a gambling debt to someone in another dorm begs the mentor to tell no one. Session 54 runs racial tension over a single TV, a scenario that needs careful handling, then reviews all five simulations, and each man rates himself on the six rubric categories for his portfolio. Every man in the room has lived near situations like these, and he will walk into them as a mentor. None of the three has a clean ending. Often the realistic win is that nobody gets hurt and the door stays open, and the men need to learn to count that as success. Block 2, in Weeks 19 and 20, asks even more of them.

What to Watch For

The racial tension simulation: This is the most sensitive scenario in Block 1. Watch for:

- Participants who check out or disengage — the topic may trigger personal experiences
- Participants who use the simulation to express genuinely held prejudices — redirect firmly: "In FORGE, every person in this dorm has dignity. That's not negotiable. We can talk about what's hard about living together. We can't talk about who doesn't deserve to be here."
- Participants who claim "I don't see color" — gently push: "That's a common thing to say. But the men you'll mentor do see color, because it shapes their daily experience. If you want to help them, you have to see what they see."
- Cross-racial interactions in the debrief — note who engages honestly across racial lines and who stays in their comfort zone. This is data for future mentoring assignments.

Fatigue by Session 54: By the end of six simulation sessions, participants are tired. The emotional energy required is significant. Acknowledge it: "This is hard work. Your brain is tired because it's growing. That's a good sign."

Skill progression across the two weeks: Review your notes from Sessions 50-54. Has each participant improved? Who made the biggest jumps? Who is plateauing? This informs your preparation for Block 2 and your individual coaching.

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Common Week 18 Challenges

"I don't want to talk about race." Address directly: "I understand. It's uncomfortable for everyone. But the dorm doesn't care about your comfort level — racial tension happens whether we're comfortable discussing it or not. A mentor who can't navigate this conversation can't lead a dorm."

"What if I'm the wrong race to intervene?" Important question. "Your race will shape how people receive you. That's real. If you're intervening in a conflict between two people of a different race, some may question your motives. That doesn't mean you don't intervene — it means you do it with extra awareness and humility. Lead with fairness, not authority. And if someone challenges you based on your race, don't argue — acknowledge it: 'I hear you. I'm not here to take sides. I'm here because nobody benefits from this going bad.'"

Participants who haven't been in the hot seat enough: By the end of Week 18, every participant should have been the mentor in at least two simulations. If anyone has only done one, prioritize them for the second run in Session 54 or schedule extra practice before Block 2.

The self-assessment is too generous or too harsh: Some participants will rate themselves all 4s. Some will rate themselves all 1s. Neither is useful. In individual check-ins, compare their self-assessment to your observations: "You rated yourself a 3 on composure. I'd agree with that — here's what I saw. You rated yourself a 4 on boundaries. I'd say 2 — here's why."

Simulation Scoring Rubric — Quick Reference

Criteria	1 (Needs Work)	2 (Developing)	3 (Competent)	4 (Exemplary)
De-escalation	Escalated or froze	Attempted but inconsistent	Effectively reduced tension	Masterful — calm, strategic
Communication	Aggressive, passive, or unclear	Some effective techniques	Clear, assertive, respectful	Exceptional — empathetic, precise
Boundaries	Overstepped or absent	Unclear boundaries	Maintained appropriate role	Modeled boundaries naturally
Resolution	No resolution attempted	Partial resolution	Reached workable agreement	Durable solution, dignity preserved
Composure	Lost composure	Recovered after losing it	Maintained composure	Composed and grounding to others
Referral judgment	Failed to refer when needed	Delayed referral	Recognized and referred timely	Proactive safety awareness

Maximum score: 24 | Minimum passing score: 15 (average 2.5 per category)

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Preparation for Week 18

- Prepare scenario cards for Simulations 3 (New Arrival), 4 (Gambling Debt), and 5 (Racial Tension)
- The racial tension simulation requires especially careful facilitation — review the scenario thoroughly and plan your debrief questions in advance
- Ensure every participant has been in the hot seat at least once before the end of Week 18
- Begin thinking about which participants may need extra practice before graded assessments in Week 23
- Have the scoring rubric available but continue emphasizing that these are practice, not graded

Week 18 Overview

Purpose: Complete the first block of simulation training with three remaining dorm conflict scenarios — each increasing in complexity and requiring more advanced judgment. By the end of this week, every participant should have been in the mentor hot seat at least twice, and the group should have a working understanding of how to intervene in a range of dorm conflicts.

Context: Participants completed Simulations 1 (property dispute) and 2 (gossip/reputation damage) last week. This week escalates the challenge: a vulnerable new arrival being pressured, an inter-dorm gambling debt, and the most sensitive scenario — racial tension in shared space. These simulations test not just de-escalation and communication, but boundaries, referral judgment, and the mentor's ability to navigate situations where there may not be a clean resolution.

Sessions This Week:

- Session 52: Simulation 3 — New Arrival Being Tested/Pressured
- Session 53: Simulation 4 — Gambling Debt Creating Tension
- Session 54: Simulation 5 — Racial Tension in Shared Space + Block 1 Review

Materials Needed:

- Simulation Scoring Rubric (copies for observers)
- Scenario cards for Simulations 3, 4, and 5 (role-player and mentor copies)
- Observer Role cards
- Lessons Learned sheets
- Journals/notebooks
- Easel paper or whiteboard for debrief notes
- Timer or watch

Room Setup: Stage area and observer semicircle (same as Week 17).

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SESSION 52: Simulation 3 — New Arrival Being Tested/Pressured

Duration: 2 hours
Session Number: 52
Facilitator(s): Program Lead + Senior Mentor (if available)

Learning Objectives

By the end of this session, participants will be able to:

1. Intervene on behalf of a vulnerable person without creating additional conflict
2. Navigate group dynamics when the people applying pressure have seniority
3. Protect someone who says they don't want help
4. Address the behavior of a FORGE participant who is part of the problem
5. Balance protection with respect for everyone's dignity

Session 52 Checklist

- ☐ Room set up with stage area and observer semicircle
- ☐ Opening circle completed — "First week at this facility" question
- ☐ Pre-simulation discussion on new arrival dynamics
- ☐ Simulation 3 scenario read and roles assigned
- ☐ First run completed: first attempt, freeze/coach, replay, debrief
- ☐ Mitchell (FORGE participant) accountability discussed
- ☐ Peterson's refusal of help explored
- ☐ Lessons learned documented (first run)
- ☐ Second run completed with different mentor — "you made it worse" complication added
- ☐ Comparison debrief conducted
- ☐ Lessons learned documented (second run)
- ☐ Closing circle completed
- ☐ Preview of Simulation 4 given (gambling debt)

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Session Plan

Opening Circle (10 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Check-in round. How are you doing? And:* ***Think back to when you first arrived at this facility. What was the first week like? What did you need that you didn't get?****"*

Send the talking piece. This question primes empathy for the scenario. Most participants will remember the vulnerability, the confusion, the testing. That memory is fuel for what comes next.

Pre-Simulation Discussion (5 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Every one of you just described some version of the same experience: showing up in a new place, not knowing the rules, being watched, being tested. Some of you were helped by someone. Most of you weren't.*
>
> *Today's simulation is about the new arrival. The man who just walked onto this dorm and is figuring out where the lines are. The group that's figuring out where he fits. And you — the FORGE mentor who sees something happening and has to decide what to do about it.*
>
> *This scenario is tricky because you're not just dealing with a conflict. You're dealing with a power dynamic. The group applying pressure has seniority and social standing. The new arrival has neither. And the new arrival might not want your help — because accepting help from a mentor might make him look weaker than he already feels.*
>
> *Let's run it."*

Simulation 3 Setup (3 minutes)

Read the scene aloud:

> *"A new arrival — Peterson — came to the dorm three days ago. He was assigned a lower bunk near the back. You've noticed that a group of three men — Davis, Franklin, and Mitchell — have been pressuring Peterson to swap his bunk location. Davis wants that lower bunk because he's had an upper bunk for months and claims seniority.*
>
> *You walk by and overhear Davis saying to Peterson: 'Look, I'm not asking again. That bunk should have been mine. You just got here. You don't know how things work yet. Make it easy on yourself.'*
>
> *Peterson is sitting on his bunk. His jaw is tight. He says quietly, 'I'm good right here.'*

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> *Franklin, standing behind Davis, says: 'He said he's good. For now.' There's a clear implication. Mitchell is a FORGE participant. He's standing with the group but hasn't said anything."*

Assign roles:

- **Mentor:** Assigned participant (prioritize someone who hasn't been in the hot seat yet)
- **Davis (the leader):** Character brief: You've been on this dorm 14 months. You feel entitled to the lower bunk. You're not threatening violence directly, but you're using social pressure and implication. If the mentor steps in, your first move is: "This isn't your business. This is between me and the new man."
- **Peterson (new arrival):** Character brief: You're scared but you don't want to show it. If the mentor tries to help you, you say: "I can handle it." You don't want to look like you need protection. But if the mentor earns your trust through respect, you'll open up slightly.
- **Franklin (enforcer):** Character brief: You follow Davis's lead. You make vaguely threatening comments but nothing specific. If confronted, you say: "I didn't threaten anybody."
- **Mitchell (FORGE participant):** Character brief: You're uncomfortable. You know this is wrong, but Davis is your friend and you don't want to pick sides. If the mentor addresses you directly, you feel caught. You might say: "I'm just standing here. I didn't do anything."
- **Observers:** Assigned to rubric categories.

Simulation 3: First Run (27 minutes)

First Attempt (5 minutes):

Let the scene play. The mentor walks up.

Facilitator watches for:

- Does the mentor address the group as a whole or pull individuals aside?
- Does the mentor confront Davis directly, risking escalation? Or does the mentor redirect without making it a power struggle?
- How does the mentor handle Peterson's "I can handle it" — does the mentor respect it or push through it?
- Does the mentor address Mitchell? This is a critical moment — a FORGE participant is part of the pressure. Ignoring it lets it slide. Calling it out in front of Davis could humiliate Mitchell. What's the right move?
- Does the mentor focus on the bunk issue (content) or the behavior (process)?

Freeze and Feedback (5 minutes):

Call "Freeze." Standard process.

> *"[Mentor's name] — what's your read on this situation? What's your biggest concern right now?"*

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Then to the group:

> *"Let's talk about the Mitchell problem. You have a FORGE participant standing with a group that's pressuring a new arrival. How do you handle that?"*

Key coaching points:

- *Don't make it a confrontation with Davis:* If you position yourself against Davis in front of his group, you've created a power struggle. He can't back down without losing face. Better approach: "Hey, Davis, can I talk to you for a second?" — pull him aside. Make it a private conversation, not a public challenge.
- *Peterson doesn't want help:* Respect that in the moment. Don't force help on someone. But check back later, privately: "Hey, Peterson, I'm [name]. I live on this dorm. If you need anything or if things get uncomfortable, I'm around." Leave the door open without pushing through it.
- *Mitchell requires a separate conversation:* Not in front of the group. Later. Privately. "Mitchell, I saw you with Davis's group earlier when they were pressing Peterson about his bunk. I'm not here to lecture you. But I am going to ask you this: Is that who you want to be in this dorm? Because that's not what FORGE is about." This is an accountability conversation, not a punishment.

Replay with Adjustments (5 minutes):

Complications to introduce:

- Davis says: "You've been in this dorm, what, four months? I've been here 14. You don't outrank me."
- Peterson says: "I told you I'm good. Stop making this bigger than it is." *(He's worried the mentor's intervention will make things worse for him after the mentor walks away.)*
- Mitchell says: "Come on, man, nobody's doing anything wrong. We're just talking."

Group Debrief (10 minutes):

Key debrief questions:

- What's the difference between protecting someone and rescuing someone? *(Protecting: ensuring no one gets harmed. Rescuing: taking over the situation in a way that makes the person more dependent, not less.)*
- Peterson's "I can handle it" — is that real or is it fear? How do you tell the difference? *(You can't always tell in the moment. That's why you check back later. If he's genuinely handling it, great. If not, the door is open.)*
- The Mitchell conversation — when do you have it, and how? *(Not in front of the group. Not in anger. But it must happen. A FORGE participant participating in intimidation — even passively — undermines the entire program.)*
- What's the realistic best outcome here? *(Davis stops pressuring Peterson — at least openly. Peterson keeps his bunk and feels supported. Mitchell gets an accountability conversation. Davis doesn't catch a charge. Nobody gets hurt. That's a win.)*

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- At what point would this require staff involvement? *(If the pressure escalates to explicit threats of violence. If you learn that the group has been targeting multiple new arrivals. If Peterson is physically prevented from using his bunk.)*

Document Lessons Learned (5 minutes)

Journal entry with the three standard questions.

Second Run: Different Mentor (30 minutes)

Run the full simulation cycle with a new mentor and new role-players. Adjust complications based on what the first run revealed.

For the second run, add: After the main intervention, Peterson approaches the mentor privately an hour later and says: "Thanks for stepping in. But you made it worse. Now they think I need a babysitter. What am I supposed to do?" This tests the mentor's ability to handle the unintended consequences of their intervention.

Debrief the second run. Compare approaches.

Document Lessons Learned (3 minutes)

Closing Circle (5 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
> *"Quick closing: **What's the hardest part about helping someone who says they don't want help?**"*

Send the talking piece.

> **Facilitator (closing):**
> *"Next session: Simulation 4. Gambling debt. Different kind of situation — the danger isn't in the room with you. It's coming from another dorm. And the person in trouble is begging you not to tell anyone. Think about that tonight. See you next session."*

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SESSION 53: Simulation 4 — Gambling Debt Creating Tension

Duration: 2 hours
Session Number: 53
Facilitator(s): Program Lead + Senior Mentor (if available)

Learning Objectives

By the end of this session, participants will be able to:

1. Assess the risk level of an inter-dorm conflict and determine whether it requires referral
2. Support an individual who is asking the mentor to keep a dangerous secret
3. Navigate the tension between confidentiality and safety obligation
4. Demonstrate MI skills with someone who is frightened and defensive
5. Recognize the limits of the mentor role when organized activity (gambling networks) is involved

Session 53 Checklist

- ☐ Room set up with stage area and observer semicircle
- ☐ Opening circle completed — "secret you shouldn't keep" question
- ☐ Pre-simulation discussion on gambling and safety
- ☐ Simulation 4 scenario read and roles assigned
- ☐ First run completed: first attempt, freeze/coach, replay, debrief
- ☐ Confidentiality vs. safety obligation discussed thoroughly
- ☐ Mentor's scope limitations discussed (cannot approach Cortez)
- ☐ Lessons learned documented (first run)
- ☐ Second run completed with different mentor — "stay out of it" warning added
- ☐ Mentor-as-target dynamics discussed
- ☐ Lessons learned documented (second run)
- ☐ Closing circle completed
- ☐ Preview and context set for Simulation 5 (racial tension)

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Session Plan

Opening Circle (10 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Check-in round. How are you doing? And:* ***Has there ever been a time in your life when someone asked you to keep a secret that you knew you shouldn't keep? What happened?****"*

Send the talking piece. This primes the central tension of today's simulation — the clash between loyalty and safety.

Pre-Simulation Discussion (5 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Gambling is a reality of prison life. Everyone in this room knows it exists. FORGE doesn't pretend it doesn't. But here's what FORGE does say: when gambling creates danger — when debts lead to threats, extortion, or violence — that's a safety issue. And safety is always within a mentor's scope.*
>
> *Today's scenario puts you in a difficult position. You learn about a situation that's dangerous. The person involved is begging you not to say anything. You're going to have to decide: Where's the line between respecting someone's privacy and protecting their safety?*
>
> *There's no easy answer. That's the point."*

Simulation 4 Setup (3 minutes)

Read the scene aloud:

> *"You're sitting in the day room when a dorm member named Harris walks up. He's usually talkative, but today he's quiet and keeps looking over his shoulder. He sits down next to you and says, almost under his breath: 'I need to talk to you. But you can't say anything to anyone. I mean it.'*
>
> *You agree to listen. Here's what Harris tells you:*
>
> *He's been gambling — sports bets, mostly. He lost. A lot. He owes a man named Cortez in C-Dorm — someone he doesn't know well. The debt started at 10 soups and has grown to 5 books of stamps and commissary worth about $200. Cortez sent word through someone yesterday: 'Payment is due by the end of the week or we'll come collect.'*

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> *Harris is scared. He doesn't have the commissary to pay. He doesn't want to tell staff because he's worried about being labeled and because gambling itself can get him written up. He wants you to help him figure out a way to get the commissary together — maybe borrow from other people in the dorm.*
>
> *You're his FORGE mentor. Go."*

Assign roles:

- **Mentor:** Assigned participant
- **Harris:** Character brief: You're terrified but covering it with nervous energy. You want the mentor to help you solve the money problem, not make it bigger. If the mentor suggests involving staff, you shut down: "No. Absolutely not. If staff gets involved, I'm the one who gets in trouble for gambling. And Cortez will know I talked. That makes it worse, not better." If the mentor uses MI and explores what you're really feeling, you'll gradually reveal that you're afraid you're going to get hurt. If pushed too hard, you say: "Forget it. I shouldn't have said anything."
- **Observers:** Assigned to rubric categories.

Note: This is a one-on-one conversation. No bystanders, no confrontation. The entire simulation is a mentoring conversation that tests judgment.

Simulation 4: First Run (27 minutes)

First Attempt (5 minutes):

The mentor and Harris sit together. Let it play out.

Facilitator watches for:

- Does the mentor validate Harris's fear before doing anything else?
- Does the mentor start problem-solving immediately (helping Harris find commissary) or does the mentor step back and assess the risk first?
- When Harris says "Don't tell anyone" — how does the mentor respond? Automatic agreement? Honest acknowledgment with limits?
- Does the mentor recognize that this has crossed from a personal problem into a safety concern? "We'll come collect" is a threat.
- Does the mentor ask the right questions? ("How well do you know Cortez?" "Has he been violent before?" "Has anyone else been in this situation with him?" "What do you think 'come collect' means?")
- Does the mentor try to solve it alone or does the mentor recognize this may be beyond peer mentoring scope?

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Freeze and Feedback (5 minutes):

Call "Freeze."

> *"[Mentor's name] — right now, in this moment, do you think Harris is safe? What's your honest assessment?"*

Let the mentor respond. Then:

> *"Group — let's talk about the confidentiality question. Harris asked the mentor not to tell anyone. What are the mentor's options?"*

Lay out the options clearly for the group:

> *"Option 1: Keep the secret and try to help Harris solve it privately. Risk: Harris gets hurt because the mentor underestimated the danger level. The mentor is now complicit in hiding a safety issue.*
>
> *Option 2: Go straight to staff immediately. Risk: Harris gets written up for gambling. Harris is labeled as someone who talks. Cortez retaliates. Harris loses trust in FORGE.*
>
> *Option 3: Be honest with Harris. 'I hear you, and I respect that you came to me. I'm not going to go behind your back. But I need you to understand something — if someone is threatening to hurt you, I can't sit on that. Not because I want to get you in trouble, but because keeping you safe matters more than keeping a secret. Let's figure out together what the right move is.'*
>
> *That third option is the FORGE way. It's honest. It's transparent. It preserves the relationship while honoring the safety obligation."*

Replay with Adjustments (5 minutes):

Complications to introduce:

- After the mentor's approach, Harris says: "You don't understand. Cortez has people. If he finds out I talked to anyone — anyone — it's going to be ten times worse."
- Harris reveals: "This isn't the first debt. I owed someone else three months ago. I borrowed from Cortez to pay that one off. Now I owe Cortez."
- Someone walks by and Harris goes quiet immediately, then whispers: "See? I can't even have this conversation without looking over my shoulder."

Group Debrief (10 minutes):

Key debrief questions:

- When does a gambling debt cross from a personal problem into a safety concern? *(When threats are made. When someone outside the dorm is sending messages. When the debtor is afraid for their physical safety.)*

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- Harris's request to "not tell anyone" — can a mentor ever agree to blanket confidentiality? *(No. The correct response is always: "I'll keep this between us as much as I can. But if I believe your safety is at risk, I have to act on that. I'd rather have you mad at me than hurt.")*
- Harris's gambling pattern — he borrowed from Cortez to pay a previous debt. What does that tell you? *(This is a pattern, not an isolated incident. Harris may need more than intervention on this one debt — he may need support for gambling as a behavior. This is MI territory: "What's gambling doing for you? What's it costing you?")*
- What does the mentor actually do after this conversation? *(Depends on the assessment. If the threat is credible and imminent, staff needs to be involved — with Harris's knowledge if possible. If the threat is less immediate, the mentor can work with Harris on a plan and monitor closely. Either way, the mentor documents the conversation and checks in daily.)*
- Can the mentor go to Cortez? *(Absolutely not. A FORGE mentor does not insert themselves into an inter-dorm debt situation. That's stepping into territory that could become dangerous for the mentor. This is a boundary the mentor must hold.)*

> **Facilitator (synthesis):**
>
> *"Here's the bottom line: You cannot help someone if they're not alive and safe. Confidentiality matters — hugely. But safety always outranks confidentiality. When those two things conflict, safety wins. And the way you handle that conflict — with honesty, with transparency, with care — is what separates a FORGE mentor from everyone else."*

Document Lessons Learned (5 minutes)

Second Run: Different Mentor (30 minutes)

Run the full simulation cycle with a new mentor and new Harris.

For the second run, add a third character: Later that day, a man the mentor doesn't know well approaches and says: "I hear you've been talking to Harris. Just so you know — what goes on between Harris and Cortez is their business. You might want to stay out of it." This is a warning. It tests the mentor's composure and judgment when they themselves become a target of pressure.

Debrief the second run. The warning from the third party changes everything. Discuss:

- When the mentor becomes a target, what changes?
- Does this require staff involvement? *(Yes. When someone warns you to stay out of a situation, the situation is bigger than peer mentoring.)*
- How do you protect yourself while still supporting Harris?

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Document Lessons Learned (3 minutes)

Closing Circle (5 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Quick closing:* ***What made today's simulation harder than the ones we've done so far?****"*

Send the talking piece. Most will point to the confidentiality tension and the lack of a clear "right answer."

> **Facilitator (closing):**
>
> *"Next session is the last simulation of Block 1 — and it's the most sensitive one. Racial tension in a shared space. I need to be upfront: this topic requires maturity, honesty, and respect. We're going to talk about race in the way it actually shows up in a dorm — not the way people talk about it on TV.*
>
> *Come prepared to be honest and to listen to perspectives different from yours. This is where FORGE mentors prove they can handle the hardest conversations. See you next session."*

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SESSION 54: Simulation 5 — Racial Tension in Shared Space + Block 1 Review

Duration: 2 hours
Session Number: 54
Facilitator(s): Program Lead + Senior Mentor (if available)

Learning Objectives

By the end of this session, participants will be able to:

1. Intervene in a racially charged situation without dismissing, taking sides, or escalating
2. Acknowledge racial dynamics honestly while redirecting toward shared interests
3. Recognize when racial tension is a symptom of deeper issues (resource scarcity, disrespect, fear)
4. Know the limits of what a mentor can address alone and when broader intervention is needed
5. Reflect on their own growth across all five Block 1 simulations

Session 54 Checklist

- ☐ Room set up with stage area and observer semicircle
- ☐ Opening circle completed with direct framing on racial tension
- ☐ Psychological safety re-established for sensitive topic
- ☐ Simulation 5 scenario read and roles assigned
- ☐ First run completed: first attempt, freeze/coach, replay, debrief
- ☐ Racial dynamics discussed honestly — colorblind vs. color-honest
- ☐ Practical solution and deeper conversation distinguished
- ☐ Lessons learned documented
- ☐ Block 1 review completed — all five simulations summarized
- ☐ Through-line themes identified (composure, listening, boundaries, judgment)
- ☐ Personal self-assessment on rubric categories completed
- ☐ Closing circle completed
- ☐ Homework assigned (lessons learned summary + continue MI practice + read ahead)

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Session Plan

Opening Circle (10 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Check-in round. How are you doing today?"*

Then, before moving on:

> *"Before we run today's simulation, I want to say something directly. Today's scenario deals with racial tension. This is a reality of prison life. It shows up in seating arrangements, in TV choices, in who eats with whom, in who has whose back. Some of you live in dorms where the lines are clearly drawn. Some of you have managed to build relationships across those lines. Either way, this is real.*
>
> *What I need from everyone today is this:* ***honesty and respect.*** *You can be honest about what racial dynamics look like in your dorm without being disrespectful. You can acknowledge that tensions exist without endorsing them. And you can practice intervening without pretending to have all the answers.*
>
> *FORGE mentors don't pretend race doesn't matter. They also don't accept that racial division is inevitable. You're training to build a culture where everyone has dignity — and that means being able to navigate conversations that most people avoid.*
>
> *Let's do this."*

Simulation 5 Setup (3 minutes)

Read the scene aloud:

> *"The TV room has two televisions. For as long as anyone can remember, one TV has been controlled by Black dorm members and the other by white dorm members. It's not an official rule — it's an unwritten arrangement that everyone follows.*
>
> *Last week, one of the TVs broke. Now there's one TV and two groups who are used to watching different things. For the first few days, people took turns informally. But now it's breaking down.*
>
> *Tonight, a group of Black dorm members is watching a basketball game. A white dorm member named Reeves walks up and says, 'Game's over in 20 minutes and then we're watching something else. That's the deal.' A Black dorm member named Cooper says, 'The game's got 45 minutes left. You can wait.' Reeves says, 'We waited last night. And the night before. It's always the same — you all take the TV every night and we get whatever's left.'*

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> *The room is getting tense. Other people from both groups are watching. Someone from Cooper's group says, 'If you got a problem with it, take it up with the CO.' Reeves says, 'I don't need a CO to handle this.' The implication is clear.*
>
> *You're a FORGE mentor standing in the doorway. You can see this going bad. Go."*

Assign roles:

- **Mentor:** Assigned participant
- **Reeves:** Character brief: You feel like your group is being treated unfairly. You're frustrated, not racist — in your mind, this is about fairness, not color. But you're using language that draws racial lines. If the mentor tries to mediate, you'll cooperate if you feel heard. If you feel dismissed, you'll dig in: "Every time I bring this up, I'm the bad guy. That's how it always works."
- **Cooper:** Character brief: You see Reeves's complaint as entitlement. You've been here longer. You didn't break the TV. You're not going to be told when you can and can't watch a game. If the mentor steps in, you'll cooperate if the mentor is fair. If you feel like the mentor is siding with Reeves, you'll say: "Oh, so now FORGE is taking sides too?"
- **Bystander from Cooper's group:** Character brief: You escalate subtly. "We don't have to listen to this." "Let him go talk to the CO." You're testing whether the mentor will stand up or fold.
- **Observers:** Assigned to rubric categories.

Simulation 5: First Run (27 minutes)

First Attempt (5 minutes):

The mentor enters the room. Let the scene play.

Facilitator watches for:

- Does the mentor acknowledge the racial dynamic or pretend it's just about a TV?
- Does the mentor take sides — even subtly?
- Does the mentor address both Reeves and Cooper with equal respect?
- Does the mentor try to solve the TV problem (practical solution) or address the underlying tension (relationship issue)? Both are needed.
- How does the mentor handle the bystander who's escalating?
- Does the mentor maintain composure when someone says, "FORGE is taking sides"?

Freeze and Feedback (5 minutes):

Call "Freeze."

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> *"[Mentor's name] — what's the real issue here? Is it the TV?"*

Let the mentor respond. The right answer: No. The TV is the trigger. The real issue is perceived unfairness, competing group interests, and racial tension that has been managed by separation — and now the separation is gone.

> *"Group — this is one of the hardest situations a mentor can face. Let's talk about why."*

Key coaching points:

- *Acknowledge the racial dynamic without making it the entire conversation:* "I can see this has gotten tense, and I know some of it goes deeper than the TV. I'm not going to pretend otherwise. But right now, we have a practical problem — one TV, two groups. Let's start there." This names the elephant in the room without making anyone feel accused.
- *Don't take sides:* The mentor must be perceived as genuinely neutral. If either group feels the mentor is siding with the other, trust is gone. Talk to both Reeves and Cooper with equal respect, equal time, equal attention.
- *Solve the practical problem:* Before you can address deeper racial dynamics, you need to solve the immediate conflict. A schedule, a rotation, a coin flip — something fair and transparent. "What if we set up a schedule that both groups agree to? 30 minutes on, 30 minutes off, alternating who picks first each night." It's not profound, but it's fair.
- *Address the deeper issue — but not tonight:* Tonight is about de-escalation. The deeper conversation about racial dynamics in the dorm is important, but it can't happen when people are heated. The mentor can plant the seed: "This is bigger than the TV and we all know it. I'd like to talk about this more — but not when everyone's ready to fight. Let's solve tonight and talk about the rest when things are calm."
- *Know the limits:* A FORGE mentor cannot solve systemic racial tension in a prison dorm. That's a reality shaped by decades of history, institutional culture, and survival instincts. What a mentor CAN do: model respectful cross-racial interaction, create spaces for honest conversation, build one-on-one relationships across lines, and refuse to participate in division.

Replay with Adjustments (5 minutes):

Complications to introduce:

- Cooper says: "You don't understand what it's like. You're [same race as Reeves / different context]. Of course you'd see it his way." *(This challenges the mentor's neutrality based on their identity.)*
- Reeves says: "I'm not racist. I just want things to be fair. But every time I say that, I'm the one who looks bad." *(This is a common statement that requires acknowledgment without validation of the underlying framing.)*

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- A third person from the doorway says: "This dorm was fine until they started mixing people. Some things should just stay separate." *(This tests whether the mentor addresses overtly segregationist thinking.)*

Group Debrief (12 minutes):

This debrief requires extra care. Facilitate firmly but sensitively.

> **Facilitator:**
> *"Let's talk about this honestly. Raise your hand if racial tension exists on your dorm."*

Most or all hands will go up.

> *"Right. So this isn't theoretical. This is your life. Let me ask some hard questions."*

Debrief questions:

- When the mentor walks into this situation, is the goal to fix racial tension? *(No. That's a generational project. The goal tonight is to prevent violence, solve the practical problem, and keep the door open for deeper conversation.)*
- When Cooper says, "You don't understand, you're [race]" — what does the mentor do? *(Acknowledge it: "You're right that I see things from my own experience. I'm not pretending to know exactly what this is like for you. What I do know is that nobody in this room benefits from this turning into a fight." You don't argue about whether race matters. It does. You acknowledge it and refocus on the shared interest: safety and fairness.)*
- When someone says, "Some things should just stay separate" — does the mentor let that slide? *(No. But the mentor doesn't lecture either. Something like: "I hear you. And I know that's how a lot of people feel. FORGE is built on a different idea — that we can share this space with respect, even when we're different. That's not easy, and I'm not going to pretend it is. But it's what we're working toward.")*
- What's the difference between being colorblind and being color-honest? *(Colorblind: "I don't see race." — That dismisses people's real experiences. Color-honest: "Race shapes our experiences in here. I see that. And I still believe we can treat each other with dignity." — That's realistic and respectful.)*

> **Facilitator (synthesis):**
> *"Racial tension in a dorm is one of the hardest things a mentor will face. There's no script for it. There's no five-step model that makes it clean. What FORGE asks of you is this: Don't pretend it doesn't exist. Don't make it worse. Solve the immediate problem. Keep people safe. And when the moment is right, create space for honest conversation. That's all anyone can do. But doing that — consistently, with integrity — changes a dorm over time."*

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Document Lessons Learned (5 minutes)

Block 1 Simulation Review (20 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"We've completed five simulations over the past two weeks. Let's step back and look at the big picture."*

Reviewing all five simulations:

> *"We covered:*
>
> 1. ***Property dispute** — Two men, rising tempers, a crowd forming. You learned: Address the respect underneath the stuff. Manage the crowd. De-escalate before you resolve.*
> 2. ***Gossip and reputation damage** — A man labeled a snitch. You learned: Assess the safety level. Listen before you act. Hold the boundary when someone asks you to be their enforcer.*
> 3. ***New arrival being pressured** — A vulnerable person saying, 'I don't need help.' You learned: You can't force help on someone. But you can make yourself available. And you address FORGE members who participate in intimidation.*
> 4. ***Gambling debt** — A secret someone doesn't want you to share. You learned: Safety overrides confidentiality. Be honest about your limits. Don't insert yourself into inter-dorm dynamics.*
> 5. ***Racial tension** — The deepest, most complex situation. You learned: Acknowledge what's real. Stay neutral without being blind. Solve the practical problem first. Don't try to fix what took decades to build — just start."*

Group reflection:

> *"I want to hear from you. What's the through-line? What skill showed up in every single simulation?"*

Let 4-5 people respond. Guide toward these themes:

- **Composure** — Every scenario tested your ability to stay calm.
- **Listening** — In every scenario, the mentor who listened first did better than the mentor who acted first.
- **Boundaries** — Knowing what's your role and what isn't saved mentors from making situations worse.
- **Judgment** — Not every situation has the same solution. You have to read the room and adjust.

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> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Here's what I want every one of you to hear: **You are further along than you think.** Two weeks ago, the idea of standing up in front of this group and responding to a conflict in real time scared most of you. Today, you've done it. You've been coached. You've improved. You've watched each other learn.*
>
> *In Weeks 19 and 20, we move to Simulation Block 2 — the situations get harder. Someone with a weapon. A mental health crisis. A mentor being manipulated. These will test everything you've learned, plus things you haven't faced yet.*
>
> *But you're ready. Not because you're perfect — because you've practiced. And practice beats perfection every time."*

Personal Assessment (5 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Open your journals. I want you to do a quick self-assessment. Rate yourself 1 to 4 on each of the six rubric categories, based on where you think you are right now. Be honest — this is for you, not for me.*
>
> 1. *De-escalation: 1-4*
> 2. *Communication: 1-4*
> 3. *Boundaries: 1-4*
> 4. *Resolution: 1-4*
> 5. *Composure: 1-4*
> 6. *Referral judgment: 1-4*
>
> *Then write one sentence: What's the one area I most need to develop before graded assessments?"*

Give 5 minutes. This becomes part of their Phase 2 portfolio.

Closing Circle (10 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Final round for Block 1. Complete this sentence: '**After two weeks of simulation training, I now know that I...**'"*

Send the talking piece.

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Facilitator (closing):

"Homework:

1. ***Review all five of your lessons learned entries.*** *Write a half-page summary: What are your strengths? What needs work? What surprised you?*
2. ***Continue practicing MI in real conversations.*** *You should be using OARS daily by now. It should be becoming habit, not exercise.*
3. ***Read ahead in your handbook*** *about restorative practices if available. After Simulation Block 2 in Weeks 19-20, we move into restorative circles and accountability conversations.*

You did real work these two weeks. Every one of you stood up and put yourself on the line. That takes courage. And courage is a skill, just like everything else — the more you use it, the stronger it gets.

See you next session."

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